

In the shadow of the hills, a cricketing rebellion quietly took root

Long before Himachal became a **steady supplier** of India women cricketers, Pawan Sen was fighting scepticism, parents and limited resources to keep a dream alive.

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It is a quiet day at the Himachal Pradesh Cricket Association's (HPCA) residential academy in Nagrota, 15 kilometres outside Dharamsala in Himachal Pradesh. Pawan Sen ambles across the field to explain that his students are away for their inter-zonal games. Sen is a diminutive man, but here, he stands the tallest.

He is a bit of a maverick, having spearheaded a women's residential academy for Under-15 players since 2009. In 17 years, this academy has produced four India internationals: Sushma Verma, Harleen Deol, Renuka Singh Thakur, and Tanuja Kanwer. Two of these four are World Cup winners.

"Wherever we are in our lives, all four of us playing

today, it is because of Pawan sir. He spent countless days and nights at the academy. He was the coach, the physio, the mentor, the trainer, and everything in one," says Tanuja, who joined the academy in 2011 at her father's insistence. Laying the foundation for what would become a feeder belt for Himachal's women's cricket was hardly straightforward.

"I was shocked. I joined HPCA as a coach in 2007. There was a residential academy for boys at the Dharamsala stadium, where I

